



Learn to Knit an Heirloom Wardrobe

Seven Steps to Make More than Bad Rectangles



A K N I T T I N G G U I D E

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W E L C O M E

My Knit History



When I was a young girl, I'd sit in my great-grandmothers' sitting room eating tootsie rolls, watching Ellen on FULL volume, and learning to knit. Long before a Mayo Clinic study found that crafts like knitting were linked to a 30–50% lower likelihood of mild cognitive impairment, my Mom-mom and Gigi were proving it — telling my sisters and me stories of their glory days while passing down their knitting and crocheting skills. They kept working deep into their 90s, making sure each great-grandchild had a hand-knit Christmas stocking, and that even some great-great-grandchildren got their final baby blankets.

For years, I honored their legacy by knitting bad rectangles in terrible chunky chenille yarn. Pot holders. Doll blankets. Scarves that were either far too short or much too long. Any kind of rectangle you could think of, I would make.

In my mid-20s, I returned to knitting, making my husband a nice green scarf for a Christmas present one of those early-marriage years with a tight budget. Then the kids needed winter hats, and I pulled out some old yarn from the attic storage totes and did what I could with some unmarked circular needles and a Pinterest pattern.

Then I was 31 and pregnant with my fourth baby, getting ready for a work conference and convinced I could only really crush it if I had a handmade grey-blue vest to pull together some navy slacks. I found a random pattern, worked from the bottom up (not necessarily typical, but I didn't know that), and went to work. I didn't finish in time for the conference. In fact, I didn't finish at all. By the time I was ready to sew all the seams together, none of them matched up. I still don't know how one side of the vest ended up longer than the other. It defies the laws of knitting. It's a fiber-art miracle. But along the way, I got more integrated into the knitting world online, and I found out about the Step-by-Step Sweater — basically God's gift to anyone wanting to learn to make garments.

That was November. By January, I had a brand-new baby and a finished sweater. I wore that sweater to my first postpartum appointments, I cast on a new project (a Sophie Hood, one of the few patterns to break out of the knitting world into the larger fashion zeitgeist), and I wound yarn in the NICU when my brand-new baby was readmitted for what ended up being sepsis.

Like Tetris after a traumatic event, knitting saved me during a medically complicated postpartum period, through my own flare-ups and diagnoses in the subsequent years, and most recently as I recovered from endometriosis surgery. Two weeks in bed, I flew through three sweaters while listening to The Unselected Journals of Emma M. Lion.

I love clothes. I love color. I love knitting. And I love feeling creative and productive even on days when I can't get out of bed. Knitting feels like my heritage and my culture, my favorite hobby and a way I can love and clothe my people (and myself!). Knitting is art and craft and also, truly, not that hard.

I invite you to learn how to knit with me. Will you have a finished sweater tomorrow? No. Can you have one in the next two months? You sure can.

Knitting is something you can do a little bit at a time. While your kids play at the park, while you watch Parks and Rec for the 12th time, while you listen to a book (double hobby duty!) or wait in the pickup line. You can have a goal of ten rows a day, or ten stitches. Or ten items a year! It grows with you. But you have to start somewhere, and you have to start sometime.

This guide helps you start today. Let's knit together!



S T E P Z E R O

Knit & Purl



The two stitches that unlock everything.

- ◆ Master the knit stitch and the purl stitch.
- ◆ Several styles work — English, Continental, and more.
- ◆ Focus on even tension and not dropping stitches.
- ◆ Know these two, and thousands of sweaters open up.

If you have never touched knitting needles in your life, here's where to start: the knit stitch and the purl stitch. There are different ways to make these two stitches, and some people have Big Opinions about which is better.

Neither is better. I learned to knit and purl English style (also called throwing), and now tend to use Continental style more (also called picking) — especially when I'm doing continuous knit stitches in the round for inches at a time, or when I'm doing ribbing, since it's more fluid for me to switch the yarn from front to back that way. Sometimes I'll switch it up just to give my wrists a break from repeating one or the other and getting sore.

In the end, pick one. I've linked options for either. If you're a crocheter, Continental might be easier for you, because how you hold the needle is more similar. But just pick one and get to practicing.

To practice, you'll need to cast on. This is usually the step your foremother would have done for you if you learned as a child, but it's really not scary, and quite easy once it's muscle memory. I learned the long-tail cast on and still use it for 98% of my projects. I've linked a video for that as well.

In many patterns, you'll see "stockinette" stitch referenced. That's when you knit a knit stitch across the "right side" (RS) and a purl stitch across the "wrong side" (WS). It gives you one side full of smooth V stitches (the stockinette side) and the other side full of bumpy ~ stitches (the "purl side," or reverse stockinette).

Once you've made a good rectangle in stockinette, you'll need to "bind off," which basically closes the stitches so they can't unravel. Learn a common technique for it, then cut your yarn with about six inches of tail left.

Finally, you'll want to "weave in your ends" so those yarn tails disappear into the knit and can't come loose. It's a bit of a faff, but you need it for every single pattern — not just at the end, but any time you join in a new skein of yarn. (You'll want a tapestry needle for this; it's in the supplies list.)

SKILLS LIBRARY LINKS

[Long-tail cast on](#)

[English knit stitch](#) · [English purl stitch](#)

[Continental knit stitch](#) · [Continental purl stitch](#)

[Stockinette stitch](#) · [Beginner bind off](#)

[Weave in your ends](#) · [Add a new skein of yarn](#)

S T E P O N E

Your Needles



Throw out the iconic ideal of two wooden needles.

- ◆ Circular needles knit both flat and in the round.
- ◆ Choose fixed needles or an interchangeable set.
- ◆ Go by millimeters, not US size (4 mm = US 6).
- ◆ The cord length sets your maximum circumference.

When you picture knitting, or when you see it depicted in movies and television, you usually see little old ladies working on two long wooden needles. But these days, most garments like sweaters and hats are knit on circular needles — two short needle tips joined by a flexible cord. Not as idyllic, but they keep the weight of the knit in your lap and not dragging on your wrists. They also hold a lot of stitches, and allow for circular knitting, which is the basis of most modern patterns.

Fixed v. interchangeable circular needles

You can absolutely buy fixed circular needles — one size, one cord length, permanently joined — as you need them.

But my preference, and what I'd point you toward if you think this is a hobby you'll stick with, is an interchangeable set: a case of needle tips in every size plus a handful of cords in different lengths, all screwing together however you need. You buy once, and you can use it not just for this pattern, but basically any pattern with yarn of any size.

What I actually use

- ◆ [Infinity Hearts Alux Rainbow interchangeable set](#) — the first set I bought, and I still use it all the time. Aluminum, 13 sizes, cords from 60–150 cm. One of the cheapest sets you can get.
- ◆ [Knitter's Pride Day & Nite interchangeable set \(5" tips\)](#) — a more recent buy, now used on almost every project, specifically for sleeves. The shorter 5" tips are lovely in the hand, especially on smaller circumferences.
- ◆ [KnitPicks Reflections fixed circular](#) — an example of the shorter fixed circulars I keep on hand for sleeves, collars, and hats that need a short cord. I have a set almost identical to this that are unmarked, and I don't remember how they came to be with me.
- ◆ [KnitPro Zing "Melodies of Life" interchangeable set](#) — not mine yet, but probably my next purchase.

A few things worth knowing

- ◆ Needles come in a US size and a millimeter size, and they don't line up intuitively (a 4 mm needle is a US 6 — idk why, and it's different in different countries, like shoes). So I just go by millimeters and never think about it again.

- ◆ Wood or metal is a real preference some people feel strongly about. I don't have strong feelings, but given the choice I reach for metal. If you are Someone Who Wants the Best, ChiaoGoo needles are widely considered the gold standard (or criminally overrated, depending on who you ask).
- ◆ For the tricky small bits — the crown of a hat, sleeves — you may see patterns mention DPNs (double-pointed needles). I avoid those whenever I can and use the "magic loop" method or short "shortie" needles instead. Watch the [magic loop method](#) so it's not scary later.



BEFORE YOU BEGIN

A few things to buy sooner rather than later

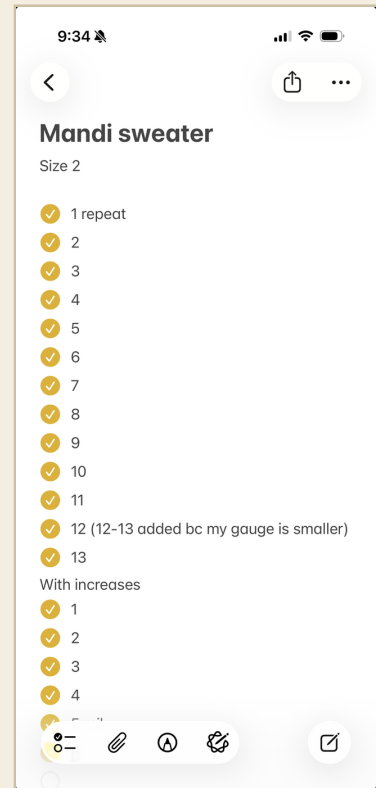
Most of this makes life easier rather than being strictly required — though a tapestry needle you'll genuinely need from your very first project.

- ◆ [Tapestry needle](#) — a blunt, large-eyed needle for weaving in your ends. You'll reach for it on every single project, starting with your first stockinette rectangle.
- ◆ [Stitch markers](#) — little rings that either live on your needle (to mark the beginning of your round, or your raglan lines) or clip through a specific stitch. I like the clip-and-unclip kind best; this is the exact pack I use.
- ◆ [Needle stoppers](#) — they cap the ends of your needles so your stitches can't slide off while the project sits in a bag. I have these exact strawberry ones.

How I keep track of where I am

I've bought little row-counter gadgets and never once stuck with them. Here's the system that actually works for me and isn't fiddly: I make a new note in my phone for each project, titled with the pattern name. At the top I write which size I'm knitting and any essential notes. Then, whenever the pattern says to do something for a number of rows, I use the checklist-bubble feature to list out each row, and I just tap one off as I finish it. That's the whole system.

If I end up making custom changes to one part of the garment that I want to remember repeating elsewhere — such as changing the rate of decreases on the left arm that I want to match on the right — I also note that. If I stop mid-project, I can jot a note on where to pick back up and then delete it later. It's just a really clean, dumb solution.



My row-tracking note.



S T E P T W O

Understanding Yarn



Learn the rules and how to break them.

- ◆ Composition: merino, alpaca, mohair, acrylic, and blends.
- ◆ Weight: the numbered scale, matched to a needle size.
- ◆ Gauge & blocking — always swatch (do as I say...).
- ◆ Hold yarns double, or substitute with YarnSub.

Yarn can feel like the overwhelming part, so let's make it simple. When you read a pattern, it will usually tell you exactly what yarn was used to make the garment in the photos, what size needle, and — for circular needles — what length of cord, since the cord length is the limiting factor for circumference.

If you feel genuinely overwhelmed, don't. Buy the exact yarn they bought and get to work — don't let this be an impediment. But you do not *have* to use the specific yarn the designer used. With any project, you can use the yarn the designer chose to tell you what to look for in your own yarn selection. There are two things to understand: what the yarn is made of, and how heavy it is.

Composition: what it's made of

Yarn is spun from all sorts of fibers, and each behaves a little differently:

- ♦ Acrylic — synthetic, inexpensive, machine-washable, hard-wearing. Great for learning and for items that need to survive a washing machine; less breathable and less "special" to knit with.
- ♦ Sheep's wool (like merino) — the classic. Warm, springy, forgiving, holds its shape. Merino is soft enough to wear against most skin. This is my usual starting point.
- ♦ Alpaca — warmer than wool, silky, with a lovely drape; less springy, so it can grow and stretch.
- ♦ Mohair — fuzzy and light, usually a very fine "lace" weight, often held together with another yarn to add a soft halo.
- ♦ Silk — luxurious, with a soft sheen and beautiful drape. Strong but not springy, so it holds less shape; often blended with wool for the best of both.
- ♦ Cotton — plant-based, breathable, and cool to wear, great for warm-weather knits. Heavier and less elastic than wool, so it can be harder on the hands and less forgiving.
- ♦ Cashmere — incredibly soft and warm, from goats. A splurge fiber, usually blended to add softness and a little halo.

You'll also see modifiers like "superwash wool." That means the fibers have been treated to tolerate machine washing better — convenient, but it changes how the yarn behaves. Superwash usually grows more when it's washed and blocked, so keep that in mind.

Weight: how heavy it is

Yarn is grouped by thickness, on a numbered scale, and the ball band will tell you which group a yarn belongs to plus a recommended needle size. Bulkier yarns use bigger needles. Yarn is sold by weight (50 g, 100 g), with a length given for that weight — for example, 210 m per 100 g, which is an actual DK yarn in my stash. Thicker yarns give you less length per gram, but they also take up more space when knit, because the fiber itself is bigger. Make sense?

Gauge & blocking

On a pattern, you'll see the designer note the gauge of the yarn they used. Gauge is basically how the yarn knits up — usually written as the number of stitches and rows that fit into a 10 cm (4 inch) square. You knit a swatch, measure how many stitches and rows you get across that square, and make sure it matches the designer's number. If you're getting too few stitches (yours is looser/bigger) or too many (tighter/smaller), you either switch to smaller or larger needles, knit a different size, or choose a different yarn.

I will note: you should not just knit a swatch but also wash and block the swatch, because especially with some yarn types like superwash, the project will grow massively with washing and blocking.

What is blocking? Blocking is wetting or steaming your finished knit or swatch, and then drying it intentionally. This can help customize fit and shaping, smooth stitches, and reveal yarn behavior.

I will tell you, unequivocally, you should always knit and block a swatch. Do I always? Or even often? I do not. And this works well UNTIL IT DOESN'T and you've spent forty hours knitting a sweater that now fits a Dr. Seuss character.

SKILLS LIBRARY LINKS

[How to wash and block your knits](#)

A little yarn math

When you're ready to be a little adventurous, you can swap and combine yarns at will. It's very common to hold two yarns together and knit them as if they were one — many patterns call for holding a sport or DK yarn with a strand of lace-weight mohair, and even when a pattern doesn't call for it, you can choose to.

To figure out what two held-together yarns add up to, I use a simple numbering of my own. Using this system, I can create ways of building up to bulkier yarns by holding multiple strands together. This is a great way to work in multiple colors or textures.



My Yarn Math

Mix and match, as long as it maths.

1	Lace
2	Fingering
3	Sport
4	DK
5	Worsted
6	Aran
7	Bulky

EXAMPLES OF HOW THE MATH CAN MATH

Lace (1) + Worsted (5) = Aran (6)
Fingering (2) + Fingering (2) = DK (4)

If you want to check your work on a one-to-one substitution, use yarnsub.com — search a yarn and get an exhaustive list of good substitutes. For a clean one-to-one swap, look for a yarn with the same composition (100% merino, or 90% acrylic / 10% alpaca, etc.) and the same meterage per gram, or very close. That gets you the same weight and the same feel.

For your hat, coming up next, all of this is low-stakes. Just pick and move forward. Worst case it comes out a bit big or small and finds a different head. On a sweater, with more geometry, small anomalies compound. So build the habit now while it doesn't matter much.

Where I buy yarn

When I first started knitting garments instead of rectangles, I bought whatever color I liked at Michaels. Then I started buying at Michaels but looking for their wool lines, because I began to care about composition. Then I graduated to places like rito.com, LindeHobby.com, and Hobbii.com. I especially love the Drops brand — Drops Daisy, Drops Karisma — for great quality at a great price, in big quantities and endless colors. Perfect for a dopamine knit.

When I want nice yarn for an heirloom piece or a treat, I love Knitting for Olive (the best colors), Sandnes Garn, or yarn local to somewhere I'm traveling — British yarn from West Yorkshire Spinners, for instance. Be warned: buying and collecting yarn is a whole separate hobby from knitting, and finding the right balance between buying for a project and buying because it's beautiful (and you'll find a project later) is a lifelong journey.



S T E P T H R E E

Your First Project: A Ribbed Hat



A hat is a sweater in miniature.

- ◆ Practice ribbing and decreases at a small, low-stakes scale.
- ◆ Knit an adult size — tiny baby beanies get fiddly.
- ◆ Free patterns.

Okay, obviously you cannot and should not wear a hat like a sweater. I do not want to be blamed for indecent exposure. But most of the actual stitch-level skills you need to knit a sweater, you can practice on a hat. It'll work up faster, and get you that dopamine hit! So before you cast on a whole sweater, knit a hat.

You'll practice ribbing (knits and purls alternating, which nearly every sweater uses at the cuffs, hem, and neck) and decreases (shaping the crown, exactly the skill you'll use to shape a sleeve). By the time you finish, a sweater will feel like a doable next step. You'll be like, "what's a sweater if not just eleven hats?"

Pick any ribbed or simple beanie pattern you like — there are hundreds of free ones online. One suggestion that I will really only insist upon in this one instance: knit an adult size, not a baby size. Working a tiny baby-hat circumference on circular needles gets fiddly, and you'll fight tightness and awkwardness you simply don't have to deal with at a larger size. We want to minimize the variables that could get between you and a good first experience.

A few good hat patterns

- ♦ [Classic Ribbed Hat — Purl Soho](#) (free).
- ♦ [Easy Beginner Hat — Handy Little Me](#) (free).
- ♦ [September Hue — PetiteKnit](#) (paid, but not expensive — and PetiteKnit is a reliable brand for building skills and making closet-staple patterns for the whole family).

SKILLS LIBRARY LINKS

The decrease techniques you'll use to shape the crown:

[K2TOG \(knit two together\)](#) · [SSK \(slip, slip, knit\)](#)



STEP FOUR

Your First Sweater: A Top-Down Raglan



Knit in the round, from the neck down.

- ◆ Almost all of it is knit and purl worked in the round.
- ◆ Start with a step-by-step raglan like the Florence.
- ◆ You already have every skill you need.

For your first sweater, you have almost every skill you need, aside from increases, which are not more difficult than anything else you've learned. Resource videos are below.

A Top-Down Raglan refers to how a sweater is constructed, and there are literally thousands of these types of sweaters on Ravelry.com (the most ubiquitous knitting pattern/project catalogue). All it means is that the sweater is knit in the round with increases that originate with "seams" (a misnomer, but the closest word for this purpose) that extend from the neckline to the armpits. Envision a classic baseball tee with contrast-color sleeves — this exaggerates the raglan construction. And Top-Down just means it's knit from the neck edge to the hem, and not the other way around.

If you knit the hat, you can knit this.

SKILLS LIBRARY LINKS

The increases you'll use, worth a quick preview:

[M1R \(make one right\)](#) · [M1L \(make one left\)](#) · and most of the body is [stockinette](#).

Start with the Step-by-Step Sweater

I can't recommend this enough as a first garment: the [Step-by-Step Sweater](#). It's free, it's aptly named, and it comes with an [extensive video walkthrough](#) that holds your hand through every element, with beginner modifications. This is where so many newbies knit their very first sweater and actually succeed. Start here.



S T E P F I V E

Level Up



Branch out into fancy raglans.

- ◆ Try new raglans with more shaping or texture.
- ◆ Add a little colorwork, cables, or lace.
- ◆ Build a handful of real closet staples.

When you're ready to branch out using the basics you learned on the Step-by-Step Sweater, here are raglans I genuinely love and reach for:

- ♦ [Sweater No. 6 — My Favourite Things Knitwear](#) — my first "fancy" knit.
- ♦ [Frankie Sweater Junior — PetiteKnit](#) — knit the child-sized Junior first to get the skills in miniature (it goes fast), then make the grown-up [women's Frankie](#) in your own size.
- ♦ [Monday Sweater — PetiteKnit](#) — a classic.
- ♦ [Hansthalm Sweater — PetiteKnit](#) — an option for the men in your life, because knitting is also for the boys.
- ♦ [Rolled Raglan](#) — one of my latest and most favorite knits.
- ♦ [August Sweater — Ozetta Knitwear](#) — a mock neck with perfect details.

Once you've got the idea, know that any raglan will do — if you find a pattern you love, check that it's rated 4.5 stars or higher on Ravelry. That tends to correlate with clearer pattern instructions. Some designers use shorthand or make assumptions that aren't as beginner-friendly as others.



S T E P S I X

The World Is Yours



Beyond the raglan, a whole world of construction.

- ◆ Explore set-in sleeves, yokes, and bottom-up knits.
- ◆ Try new silhouettes and details.
- ◆ Follow the patterns and yarn that delight you.

There are obviously countless other ways to learn how to knit garments, but this is a Good One. Once you master a raglan, there's a whole world of other techniques to explore. Other construction methods, colorwork, striping, lacework, cables, and more. Whatever the project, it all builds off of the knit and the purl.

From here, my only advice is to follow the patterns and the yarn that delight you. That's the whole secret to knitting a closet full of things you actually want to wear: make the things you love, one stitch at a time.





APPENDIX A

Navigating the Yarn Aisle

What to look for to start your first knit.

1 Put on blinders.

Ignore the bulky, the shiny, and the chenille. No hate on the novelty yarns, but most patterns for wearables won't use such chunky yarn. And while thicker yarn might knit up faster, it's actually harder to work with, and will make getting good tension with those essential knit and purl stitches way harder.

2 What should you look for?

First, have you picked out a pattern? If you want to knit a garment that looks like the pattern promised, you need to choose a yarn similar to what the pattern maker used. Read the pattern you plan to use and note the qualities of the yarn: the weight (lace, fingering, sport, DK, worsted, aran, bulky) and the composition (wool, acrylic, alpaca, blend), and try to find something similar. If that feels like too much, look at the size of the recommended needle. When you're reading yarn bands, choose a yarn with the same needle size.

If you haven't selected a pattern yet, plan to look for a nice DK or worsted weight yarn in a wool or wool blend. Acrylic is inexpensive and readily available, but it's also a little harder to actually work up. Something with wool will give you a little more grit as you get accustomed to knitting.

3 How much to buy?

For an adult hat, my recommended first knit, you shouldn't need more than 100 g of yarn, which is one or two skeins depending on their weight. If you're worried about running out, buy two skeins.

4 What color to buy?

Whatever makes you happy. Whatever you'd like to wear. There's an argument that a solid color is better for beginners because it'll be easier to see your stitches, but if a fun variegated, nubby, or self-stripping yarn is gonna make you sit down to knit, choose that!

5 What needles to buy?

Your pattern, your yarn, or both will tell you what needles to buy, but if you're planning to work on a wearable garment, do not buy the iconic ideal of two straight knitting needles. You're looking for circular needles: two shorter needles connected by a flexible cord. A 16" to 20" cord in 4 mm, 4.5 mm, or 5 mm is likely what you want for an adult hat, but check your pattern and yarn!

6 Where to shop?

Your local craft store (RIP Joann) has everything you need for your first project. If you want more variety, the Drops brand of yarn is a great option for beginners wanting to knit garments. It's inexpensive, has a wide color range, and quite a few composition options.



APPENDIX B

How to Read a Yarn Band

The label tells you almost everything you need to know. Here's what it means.

1 Rachel's Faux Fiber Emporium HEIRLOOM DK 2 100% MERINO WOOL <i>Superwash</i> 3 100 g · 210 m / 230 yd	WEIGHT 4 DK Category 3 · Light NEEDLES 5  4 mm · US 6 GAUGE 6  22 sts × 30 rows = 10 cm	CARE 7     COLOR 8  512 Fig Plum Dye Lot 0417
--	--	--

1 Brand & yarn name

The name to remember when you want more of it, or when a pattern calls for it by name.

2 Fiber content

What it's made of. Wool is springy and forgiving; cotton is cool and less stretchy; acrylic is washable and inexpensive. Start with wool if you can, but most of all, obey your pattern.

3 Weight & length

How much yarn is in the ball. Your pattern says how much yarn you need, usually with a little wiggle room. Divide by this number to know how many balls to buy.

4 Weight category

How thick the yarn is: lace, fingering, sport, DK, worsted, aran, bulky, in order from most fine to most thick. Match your pattern when you can.

5 Needle size

The size the maker suggests. Go by millimeters, not US numbers. If your pattern calls for a size that's different than the band says, obey the pattern. Or knit a gauge swatch.

6 Gauge

How many stitches and rows make a 10 cm (4 inch) square. Knit a small swatch to check that yours matches before you cast on.

7 Care symbols

Whether it can go in the washing machine, the dryer, or under an iron. Most wool prefers a gentle hand-wash and dry, but you can't always get what you want.

8 Color & dye lot

The dye lot is the batch. Colors shift slightly between batches, so buy every ball for one project from the same lot when you can.



ONE STITCH AT A TIME

You've got this



*Let knitting into your life, and build a wardrobe you love,
for the people you love, one stitch at a time.*

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